



Trillian Astra finally goes into beta after 3 years of development



Windows Vista Service Pack 2 is slated to be released in June

Feature

via instant messengers. Messages can be sent and updates received through a mobile phone. Another very similar service is Identi.ca. It's a free and open micro blogging service that runs on backend software called Laconica.

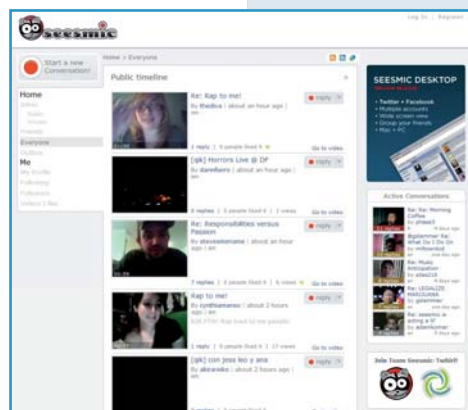
Tumblr (www.tumblr.com)

Tumblr offers an impressive interface as well, but it's not as flashy as Plurk. There



is a main dashboard, which displays all the options to the user — to post a photo, text, chat, audio, video, and so on. Tumblr has taken the components of micro-blogging services and have added on all the functionalities that you would expect from a complete blog service, on to it. Tumblr includes a schedule function which you can use to set a day when the post should be published on your blog. Another impressive feature of Tumblr is the ability to dial a US number and posting an audio blog post using a phone call.

Tumblr is a great service for you if



posting images is what you want to do. For those who want to post plain text messages, Tumblr is an overkill. It even displays a list of popular bloggers under different categories. Tumblr has a huge collection of customised themes. It gives the user a sub-domain as well so others can easily access their profile.

In conclusion

Choosing a micro blogging service is like choosing an instant messenger service — you'll always want to have as many friends as possible on a single network. Twitter seems to be doing well at that.

VIDEO MICRO BLOGGING

(www.seesmic.com)

There are those who think that text blogging is old and voice-chat is the way to go. It is, after all, a more natural way of communicating with others. Seesmic is a service that works like any other micro-blogging service; except on Seesmic, people communicate by posting video clips. Seesmic uses web cams and microphones to record posts. Pre-recorded videos can also be uploaded to the service. A 500 MB limit is set; a video can be either in the MP4 or FLV format. These videos are also downloadable. YouTube videos are also allowed. Replies can be sent in the same manner in the form of videos. They are displayed as

small videos that are viewed by the in-built flash player on each page. Clicking on the enlarge icon opens a larger version of a video. Users can follow others in the same way as they would with a text-based micro-blogging service. Videos can also be sent to other Seesmic users as well. Seesmic is at an alpha stage and the offering is interesting and different. It's definitely worth trying out; even though the presentation might not impress many — it isn't as pretty as some of the other web 2.0 startups around.

Other services have to try harder to attract users to them. With each service trying to setup a bridge between others, it's possible to post on one service and automatically have it replicated on others. Ping.fm lets you do just this. The solution you pick then depends on what you want out of such a service — there are options plenty, you just need to make a choice and get (micro)blogging! **d**

THE END OF A SERVICE

Pownce

(www.pownce.com)

Of all the offerings, one of the first micro-blogging services to fall was Pownce (www.pownce.com). Pownce was started by Kevin Rose, the co-owner and founder of Digg.com. It started in January of 2008 and was shut down in December of 2008, just days after being taken over by Six Apart, the previous owner of the famous blogging site Live Journal. Pownce had a superior set of features as compared to some of the others.

The service could be availed via an invitation-based system. It was so famous that invites

were even sold on online auctioning sites such as eBay. Some of the features that Pownce had were the ability to send messages, files, links and even set events. Files of up to 10 MB could be attached. The pro version of the service allowed even larger files. Groups out of friends could be made and sending messages to these groups was possible.

This was something not seen on most services and still isn't very common. Pownce was talked about because of Digg's huge community. It had support for mobile phones and there were clients based on Adobe's AIR developed for it. The developers said that they would come back with something much better in 2009.

WAKOOPA

As if displaying your current status and presence weren't enough; here's a service that was designed to display what software users were using. The service is Wakoopa and its been around for two years now. It's simple to use. After a registration, a small tracking program has to be downloaded and installed. This tracking application is available for Windows, Linux and Mac OS X. This application sends back statistics on the software being used and how often you use them. This data is displayed on your profile page at Wakoopa.com. Wakoopa allows you to find similar users and in turn find better and newer software that



you might have not come across. Wakoopa makes a chart of the software that you use and also creates tags according to the tasks performed by these programs. You can even click on a particular tag — chat for example, and get a list of programs for chat. There's even small signature images that you can put up on your favourite social networking site that displays your most used programs.